Lesson 22 material: Thesis Statements

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

4.2: Developing a Strong, Clear Thesis Statement

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Learning Objectives

1. Develop a strong, clear thesis statement with the proper elements.
2. Revise your thesis statement.

Have you ever known a person who was not very good at telling stories? You probably had trouble following his train of thought as he jumped around from point to point, either being too brief in places that needed further explanation or providing too many details on a meaningless element. Maybe he told the end of the story first, then moved to the beginning and later added details to the middle. His ideas were probably scattered, and the story did not flow very well. When the story was over, you probably had many questions.

Just as a personal anecdote can be a disorganized mess, an essay can fall into the same trap of being out of order and confusing. That is why writers need a thesis statement to provide a specific focus for their essay and to organize what they are about to discuss in the body.

Just like a topic sentence summarizes a single paragraph, the thesis statement summarizes an entire essay. It tells the reader the point you want to make in your essay, while the essay itself supports that point. It is like a signpost that signals the essay's destination. You should form your thesis before you begin to organize an essay, but you may find that it needs revision as the essay develops.

Elements of a Thesis Statement

For every essay you write, you must focus on a central idea. This idea stems from a topic you have chosen or been assigned or from a question your teacher has asked. It is not enough merely to discuss a general topic or simply answer a question with a yes or no. You have to form a specific opinion, and then articulate that into a controlling idea — the main idea upon which you build your thesis.

Remember that a thesis is not the topic itself, but rather your interpretation of the question or subject. For whatever topic your professor gives you, you must ask yourself, "What do I want to say about it?" Asking and then answering this question is vital to forming a thesis that is precise, forceful and confident.

A thesis is one sentence long and appears toward the end of your introduction. It is specific and focuses on one to three points of a single idea — points that are able to be demonstrated in the body. It forecasts the content of the essay and suggests how you will organize your information. Remember that a thesis statement does not summarize an issue but rather dissects it.

A Strong Thesis Statement

A strong thesis statement contains the following qualities:

Specificity. A thesis statement must concentrate on a specific area of a general topic. As you may recall, the creation of a thesis statement begins when you choose a broad subject and then narrow down its parts until you pinpoint a specific aspect of that topic. For example, health care is a broad topic, but a proper thesis statement would focus on a specific area of that topic, such as options for individuals without health care coverage.

Precision. A strong thesis statement must be precise enough to allow for a coherent argument and to remain focused on the topic. If the specific topic is options for individuals without health care coverage, then your precise thesis statement must make an exact claim about it, such as that limited options exist for those who are uninsured by their employers. You must further pinpoint what you are going to discuss regarding these limited effects, such as whom they affect and what the cause is.

Ability to be argued. A thesis statement must present a relevant and specific argument. A factual statement often is not considered arguable. Be sure your thesis statement contains a point of view that can be supported with evidence.

Ability to be demonstrated. For any claim you make in your thesis, you must be able to provide reasons and examples for your opinion. You can rely on personal observations in order to do this, or you can consult outside sources to demonstrate that what you assert is valid. A worthy argument is backed by examples and details.

Forcefulness. A thesis statement that is forceful shows readers that you are, in fact, making an argument. The tone is assertive and takes a stance that others might oppose.

Confidence. In addition to using force in your thesis statement, you must also use confidence in your claim. Phrases such as *I feel* or *I believe* actually weaken the readers' sense of your confidence because these phrases imply that you are the only person who feels the way you do. In other words, your stance has insufficient backing. Taking an authoritative stance on the matter persuades your readers to have faith in your argument and open their minds to what you have to say.

Tip

Even in a personal essay that allows the use of first person, your thesis should **not** contain phrases such as *in my opinion* or *I believe*. These statements reduce your credibility and weaken your argument. Your opinion is more convincing when you use a firm attitude.

Exercise :

On a separate sheet of paper, write a thesis statement for each of the following topics. Remember to make each statement specific, precise, demonstrable, forceful and confident.

Topics

- Texting while driving
- The legal drinking age in the United States
- Teenagers having jobs while in high school
- Advantages of being bilingual
- Maintaining a healthy life style while in college

Examples of Appropriate Thesis Statements

Each of the following thesis statements meets several of the following requirements:

- Specificity
- Precision
- Ability to be argued
- Ability to be demonstrated
- Forcefulness
- Confidence

1. Closing all American borders for a period of five years is one solution that will tackle illegal immigration.
2. Compared to an absolute divorce, no-fault divorce is less expensive, promotes fairer settlements, and reflects a more realistic view of the causes for marital breakdown.
3. Exposing children from an early age to the dangers of drug abuse is a sure method of preventing future drug addicts.
4. In today's crumbling job market, a high school diploma is not significant enough education to land a stable, lucrative job.

Tip

You can find thesis statements in many places, such as in the news; in the opinions of friends, coworkers or teachers; and even in songs you hear on the radio. Become aware of thesis statements in everyday life by paying attention to people's opinions and their reasons for those opinions. Pay attention to your own everyday thesis statements as well, as these can become material for future essays.

Now that you have read about the contents of a good thesis statement and have seen examples, take a look at the pitfalls to avoid when composing your own thesis:

- A thesis is weak when it is simply a declaration of your subject or a description of what you will discuss in your essay.

Weak thesis statement: My paper will explain why imagination is more important than knowledge.

- A thesis is weak when it makes an unreasonable or outrageous claim or insults the opposing side.

Weak thesis statement: Religious radicals across America are trying tolegislate their Puritanical beliefs by banning required high school books.

- A thesis is weak when it contains an obvious fact or something that no one can disagree with or provides a dead end.

Weak thesis statement: Advertising companies use sex to sell their products.

- A thesis is weak when the statement is too broad.

Weak thesis statement: The life of Abraham Lincoln was long and challenging.

Exercise :

Read the following thesis statements. On a separate piece of paper, identify each as weak or strong. For those that are weak, list the reasons why. Then revise the weak statements so that they conform to the requirements of a strong thesis.

1. The subject of this paper is my experience with snakes as pets.
2. The government must expand its funding for research on renewable energy resources in order to prepare for the impending end of oil.
3. Edgar Allan Poe was a poet who lived in Baltimore during the nineteenth century.
4. In this essay, I will give you lots of reasons why slot machines should not be legalized in Baltimore.
5. Despite his promises during his campaign, President Kennedy took few executive measures to support civil rights legislation.
6. Because many children's toys have potential safety hazards that could lead to injury, it is clear that not all children's toys are safe.
7. My experience with young children has taught me that I want to be a disciplinary parent because I believe that a child without discipline can be a parent's worst nightmare.

Thesis Statement Revision

Your thesis will probably change as you write, so you will need to modify it to reflect exactly what you have discussed in your essay. Your thesis may begin as a working thesis statement, an indefinite statement that you make about your topic early in the writing process for the purpose of planning and guiding your writing.

Working thesis statements often become stronger as you gather information and form new opinions and reasons for those opinions. Revision helps you strengthen your thesis so that it matches what you have expressed in the body of the paper.

You can cut down on irrelevant aspects and revise your thesis by taking the following steps:

1. Pinpoint and replace all nonspecific words, such as *people*, *everything*, *society*, or *life*, with more precise words in order to reduce any vagueness.

Working thesis: Young people have to work hard to succeed in life.

Revised thesis: Recent college graduates must have discipline and persistence in order to find and maintain a stable job in which they can use and be appreciated for their talents.

The revised thesis makes a more specific statement about success and what it means to work hard. The original includes too broad a range of people and does not define exactly what success entails. By replacing those general words like *people* and *work hard*, the writer can better focus his or her research and gain more direction in his or her writing.

2. Clarify ideas that need explanation by asking yourself questions that narrow your thesis.

Working thesis: The welfare system is a joke.

Revised thesis: The welfare system keeps a socioeconomic class from gaining employment by alluring members of that class with unearned income, instead of programs to improve their education and skill sets.

A joke means many things to many people. Readers bring all sorts of backgrounds and perspectives to the reading process and would need clarification for a word so vague. This expression may also be too informal for the selected audience. By asking questions, the writer can devise a more precise and appropriate explanation for *joke*.

Working thesis: DeKalb County schoolteachers are not paid enough.

Revised thesis: The DeKalb County legislature cannot afford to pay its educators, resulting in job cuts and resignations in a district that sorely needs highly qualified and dedicated teachers.

The linking verb in this working thesis statement is the word *are*. Linking verbs often make thesis statements weak because they do not express action. Rather, they connect words and phrases to the second half of the sentence. Readers might wonder, "Why are they not paid enough?" But this statement does not compel them to ask many more questions. The writer should ask himself or herself questions in order to replace the linking verb with an action verb, thus forming a stronger thesis statement, one that takes a more definitive stance on the issue:

- Who is not paying the teachers enough?
- What is considered "enough"?
- What is the problem?
- What are the results

3. Omit any general claims that are hard to support.

Working thesis: Today's teenage girls are too sexualized.

Revised thesis: Teenage girls who are captivated by the sexual images on MTV are conditioned to believe that a woman's worth depends on her sensuality, a feeling that harms their self-esteem and behavior.

It is true that some young women in today's society are more sexualized than in the past, but that is not true for all girls. Many girls have strict parents, dress appropriately, and do not engage in sexual activity while in middle school and high school. The writer of this thesis should ask the following questions:

- Which teenage girls?
- What constitutes "too" sexualized?
- Why are they behaving that way?
- Where does this behavior show up?
- What are the repercussions?

Tip

The best way to revise your thesis statement is to ask questions about it and then examine the answers to those questions. By challenging your own ideas and forming definite reasons for those ideas, you grow closer to a more precise point of view, which you can then incorporate into your thesis statement.

Key Takeaways

- Proper essays require a thesis statement to provide a specific focus and suggest how the essay will be organized.
- A thesis statement is your interpretation of the subject, not the topic itself.
- A strong thesis is specific, precise, forceful, confident, and is able to be demonstrated.
- A strong thesis challenges readers with a point of view that can be debated and can be supported with evidence.
- A weak thesis is simply a declaration of your topic or contains an obvious fact that cannot be argued.
- Depending on your topic, it may or may not be appropriate to use first person point of view.
- Revise your thesis by ensuring all words are specific, all ideas are exact, and all verbs express action.

2.3: Writing a Thesis Statement

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Why thesis statements are important

A thesis statement is one sentence (or sometimes two sentences) that gives the main idea of your essay. If a friend asks us, "What are you trying to say in your essay?" the thesis should give the answer. It's like a sign that tells your readers where your essay is going. The essay itself explains, justifies, and elaborates on that thesis. Figure 2.3.1 shows a physical signpost.

(Picture: signpost that reads "path")

Figure: Signpost by Andrew Tarrant (CC BY NC; author via Flickr)

Have you ever listened to or read something with a lot of examples and felt confused about the main point? That is what it is like to read an essay without a thesis statement. You get confused about how everything fits together. However, once you know the overall point a writer is trying to make you can understand how everything connects together.

Noticing organization

Let's look at some sample passages and see which is easier to understand.

Notice this!

Which is easier to understand? Why?

- I thought that students in the United States went to school with cheerleaders and football players like on television. On the other hand, when I met students in the US, they asked me if I rode a camel to school in Kuwait.
- When I came to the United States, I realized that both my new classmates and I had stereotypes about each other based on limited information we had gotten in the media. I thought that students in the United States went to school with cheerleaders and football players like on television. On the other hand, when I met students in the US, they asked me if I rode a camel to school in Kuwait.

Since the second passage contains a main idea sentence, most people will find it easier to understand.

Writing your thesis statement

Answering the prompt

If your instructor gave you a question to respond to in your essay, the thesis will generally be the answer to that question. Other times, your assignment may be more broad and you will have to write a working thesis statement based on the ideas you have for the assignment. We call it a "working" thesis statement because you may change it again before the final draft.

Criteria for a strong thesis statement

Whether you have a question to respond to or not, you will need to write your thesis statement carefully. Since your thesis statement is the "sign" that your readers will follow to understand your essay, you should take your time to carefully write and revise it. Here are some qualities of a strong thesis:

- **Arguable:** This means that someone might disagree with it. When you are writing an essay for a college class you do not want to write something that everyone already knows and agrees with. That means that there is nothing new for you to add. In addition, your writing should not be an obvious fact.
- **Specific:** You want your thesis statement to direct a precise argument in your paper. If it is too broad, the argument will be unclear and unfocused.
- **Not just personal opinion:** You want your thesis to be arguable, but also want it to be something that you have enough reasons and examples that your readers will be persuaded by. If you just share a personal opinion, that will not persuade others.

Evaluating thesis statements

Now, let's evaluate some thesis statements.

Try this!

Evaluate each thesis statement. Decide if each thesis statement is:

- an effective thesis statement or
- not arguable
- not specific
- just a personal opinion

Some thesis statements have more than one problem.

1. Stereotypes are bad.
2. I think that we should overcome biases.
3. There are benefits and drawbacks to going to another country and learning about a new culture.
4. I don't like it when people make assumptions about me and what I can do.
5. Overall, McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument for the existence of stereotype threat; the information they present is engaging, seems balanced, and helped me make sense of my own experiences.

Revising your thesis statement

As you write, continue revising your thesis statements. Here are three things to focus on:

Check if it covers the ideas in the essay

Your thesis will probably change as you write, so you will need to change it to reflect exactly what you have discussed in your essay. Working thesis statements often become stronger as we gather information and form new opinions and reasons for those opinions.

Make it more specific

Replace nonspecific words (ie people, everything, society, or life) with more precise words.

- Working thesis: People should learn to recognize their biases.
- Revised thesis: Teachers should be required to attend trainings each year to allow them to overcome their biases.

The revised thesis is more specific and arguable.

Add key information

We can ask ourselves questions about what readers will want to know.

- Working thesis: Implicit biases lead to problems with healthcare.
- Possible questions:
  - What kinds of problems does unconscious bias cause?
  - How important are these problems?
  - What are the effects of this problem?
- Revised thesis: Implicit bias is a major cause of inequalities in healthcare, leading to African American patients getting undertreated for illnesses and decreased life expectancy.

Include organization language

A strong thesis will show your reader how the essay is organized. That will help readers to focus on and understand your argument. For example, if your essay is mainly focusing on arguing in favor of one solution to a problem, you should point that out to your readers. Table 2.2.1 presents some language that can be included in a thesis statement to signal how your essay will be organized.

Table 2.3.1: Thesis statement language that can be used to signal different organization patterns

Organization feature in your essay	Signal words you can include in your thesis	Example thesis statement with signal word [in brackets]					
Concession	Although	While	Despite	In spite of	[In spite of] the clear problems with stereotypes, we cannot totally eliminate them from our thinking.	[Although] there are clear problems with stereotypes, it is impossible to totally eliminate them from our thinking.	
Solutions	we must	it is necessary to	can be overcome by	solve	solutions	Given that biases develop early in life, [it is necessary to] develop anti-bias programs for preschool children.	The problem of bias in children is serious, but it [can be partly overcome by] developing anti-bias programs for preschool children.
Causes/effects	cause	effect	lead to	result in	Better education programs for police will [result in] fewer biases and improved safety for all members of the community.	A lack of explicit training about bias for police officers is a main [cause] of discriminatory police brutality.	

Improving thesis statements

Now let's apply these techniques to some sample thesis statements.

Try this!

Here are some sample thesis statements. How can you improve them by making them more specific, adding key information, or including organization language?

- Stereotypes are bad and keep people from seeing the real me.
- Categorizing people is a natural function of the brain and identifying stereotypes reduces them.
- Stereotypes are painful and lower a person's self-esteem.
- Education is the way to overcome biases.

Evaluating your own thesis statements

Now let's apply this to your own writing:

Apply this!

Look at your own or a classmate's draft.

1. Underline the thesis statement. If you can't find one, write a new thesis statement.
2. Check the thesis statement to see if it is arguable, specific, and not just personal opinion.
3. Try to improve the thesis statement:

- check if it covers the whole essay
- replace nonspecific words
- ask key questions
- include organization language

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Links on the original page

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